

2/How Panels Work

I see the need for people to make very careful and [informed] judgments for the academic community to function. It's more as an obligation than an entitlement, and I'm willing to make those judgments because I, on the one hand, have confidence in my own experience, and on the other hand, I defer to people's judgment that would be in a position to make good decisions . . . I think it's experience-based. I would like to think that people have looked at my work and said, "This is good work and he's a very fine scholar himself, and that's why we want him to help us evaluate what's good scholarship."

Political scientist

The institutional framework of evaluation that structures funding decisions in the academic world is not secret. Nevertheless, most of this "nuts and bolts" information—ranging from funding programs' objectives and formal criteria of evaluation to how panels are formed and what panelists are asked to do—is not widely known. In this chapter, then, I describe the objectives of the five funding agencies studied and the formal evaluation criteria associated with those objectives; the structure of the evaluation process, including the role of the program officer, the selection of panelists and screeners, and the pre-deliberation ranking work; and, lastly, the mechanics of the deliberations.

Drawing on the work of Karin Knorr-Cetina, I understand these

aspects of panels as a machinery or technology of evaluation around which evaluative cultures are intertwined.¹ This technology defines and constrains possibilities. Together with institutional rules, it sets the context in which selection occurs and interactions happen—the frame and hardware for conversations across disciplinary cultures. To take only one example, confidentiality guidelines constrain public action—they limit what can be said where.

I am interested in formal descriptions of awardmaking in panel reviews, as well as in participants' representations and legitimating accounts. Here I focus in particular on the funding organizations' descriptions of the process. In the words of John Meyer and Brian Rowan, these can be viewed as “myths and ceremonies” that play a crucial role in legitimating the process—for instance, by making the criteria of selection available to the public on websites or by prefacing deliberations with an official introduction concerning the importance of the work of the panel and its rules.² Most of the unspoken and taken-for-granted aspects of interactions that shape panel deliberation are downplayed in this chapter, but they will take center stage later in the book.

An agreement not to focus on particular organizations was one of the conditions for gaining access to the funding agencies. Thus my analysis looks almost exclusively at similarities across competitions and panels and neglects many of the differences—for instance, that some competitions (such as the Society of Fellows) offer very big rewards to a few, while others offer smaller rewards to many.³ I do highlight a few organizational contrasts that do not jeopardize the anonymity of the organizations—when discussing how applicants' seniority influences the weight put on letters of recommendation, for example.

If I had aimed to conduct a full analysis of organizational decision making, I would have proceeded differently. For instance, I would likely have drawn on the rich literature on the garbage-can model

of organizational decision making, which considers how decisions that are made by many uncoordinated parties (as is the case with panels) suffer from uncertainty and may not be rational, although they may be presented as such.⁴ Moreover, I would have examined the full stream of vetting applicants, the likelihood that different categories of applicants (from public and private universities, from more or less prestigious colleges) apply to competitions, and what (unevenly distributed) resources improve their chances of getting a fellowship.⁵ Such an analysis would undoubtedly illuminate the elite character of resource distribution. Fortunately, although constraints on an organizational analysis require my downplaying some of the institutional mechanics of the evaluative process, the cultural aspects are fair game.

Program Objectives and Evaluation Criteria

The five programs I studied have as an objective the promotion of specific types of scholarship by providing income to researchers while they are on sabbatical leave or by providing grants to underwrite research expenses. The objective for each program is stated on the website of the sponsoring organization. The International Dissertation Field Research (IDFR) program sponsored by the Social Science Research Council (SSRC) is open to the social sciences and the humanities; so, too, is the Women's Studies Dissertation Grant program of the Woodrow Wilson National Fellowship Foundation (WWNFF).⁶ The Humanities Fellowship program funded by the American Council of Learned Societies (ACLS) supports research in the humanities, and in humanities-related social sciences. The Society of Fellows funds work across a range of fields; and the anonymous foundation supports work only in the social sciences. These competitions also target scholars at different career stages: the SSRC

and the WWNFF programs provide support to graduate students; the ACLS holds distinct competitions for assistant, associate, and full professors; the Society of Fellows provides fellowships to recent PhDs only; and the anonymous social science foundation supports researchers at all ranks. I take the funding organizations' stated objectives at face value in this chapter. Chapters 4, 5, and 6 explore the different meanings and levels of importance that panelists assign to the program objectives and target populations and see how these understandings affect the evaluation process.

Although many panelists emphasize in only a limited way the particular objectives of funding agencies, these goals influence panel deliberations. For instance, program officers will at times encourage panelists to "factor in" various kinds of diversity in distributing awards. Moreover, some competitions aim to promote distinctive types of scholarship and this objective contributes to the overall context of evaluation, because panelists may be asked how proposals measure up to such explicit goals. This is notably the case for the IDFR program, which was created in 1996 to replace older SSRC funding programs in area studies. In the 1990s, the SSRC leadership concluded that area studies needed to move in a more theoretical, interdisciplinary, and comparative direction.⁷ They set up the IDRF program as a tool for agenda-setting, with the explicit goals of encouraging graduate students to

use their knowledge of distinctive cultures, languages, economies, polities, and histories, in combination with their disciplinary training, to address issues that transcend their disciplines or area specializations . . . The current program operates on the premise that societies and cultures, from isolated villages to entire world regions, are caught up in the processes that link them to events, which—though geographically distant—are culturally, economi-

cally, strategically, or ecologically quite near. To learn more about values or social conditions in a particular area, then, means to learn more about how that area is situated in events and processes going on outside its borders, but not thereby outside its culture or economy or ecology.⁸

Similarly, the WWNFF's Women's Studies Dissertation Grant program was created to "encourage original and significant research about women that crosses disciplinary, regional, or cultural boundaries."⁹ In the foundation's newsletter, WWNFF past president Robert Weisbuch justified support of research in women's studies by citing the interdisciplinary character of this field of scholarship, its questioning of hardened boundaries, its role as a catalyst for energetic debates, and its immediacy (women's studies is a field "not merely academic, divorced from our lives").¹⁰ The WWNFF program has played a very important role in the promotion and development of the field of women's studies in the United States.

The five funding programs' formal criteria of evaluation are summarized in Table 2.1. These criteria are in line with those typically used at other funding agencies, such as the National Science Foundation. Making formal evaluative criteria public increases accountability and makes winning democratically available to all (since success depends on the display of technical proficiency), as opposed to a domain of the talented few. These technical criteria, which address the quality of the proposed research, are discussed in detail in Chapter 5. Beyond assessing quality, however, funding agencies also consider the interdisciplinarity of proposals, and the diversity (by institution, discipline, geographic location, race/ethnicity, and gender) of applicants. Chapter 6 takes a close look at the various meanings that panelists give to these criteria and how these are used in conjunction with the formal specifications.

Table 2.1 Criteria of evaluation used by funding agencies

Agency	Intellectual and/or				Quality	Feasibility	Others
	Clarity	Originality	social significance	Methods			
Anonymous			Yes	Yes (appropriate methodology)	Yes (grasp of relevant literatures) Yes	Yes (necessary skills and experience) Yes (training; past experience; plan of work)	Fits with goals of foundation; interdisciplinary
ACLS	Yes		Yes				
IDRF	Yes (clear, intelligible prose; clearly formulated)			Yes (responsive to methodological concerns; provides rationale for field research)		Yes (knowledge of relevant concepts and theories; realistic in scope; appropriate level of training for fieldwork)	Multidisciplinarity; speaks to cross-regional panel
Society of Fellows			Yes	Yes	Yes ("scholarly excellence")		Teaching experience; contributes to an interdisciplinary community
WWNFF's Women's Studies Dissertation Grant	Yes	Yes	Yes (contribution to women's studies)	Yes ("scholarly validity")		Yes (preparation; readiness; reasonable timeline)	

Note: Criteria are from <http://www.acls.org/fel-comp.htm>; <http://programs.ssrc.org/idrf/>; and <http://www.woodrow.org/womens-studies/index.php>. "Yes" indicates the criterion is used in evaluating proposals. Except as indicated by quotation marks, all the specific criteria noted are paraphrased.

Recruitment and the Role of the Program Officer

The evaluation process adopted by the ACLS resembles that of most of the other funding organizations I studied. As an internal ACLS document explains:

ACLS has developed an intensive peer-review process to select its Fellows. The process combines screening by readers from the applicants' academic field with review by interdisciplinary panels. At the first stage of the outside peer review process, each of the applicants is prescreened by two scholars in the general field (seventeen prescreening fields include anthropology, art history, archaeology, classics, English, modern foreign languages, etc.) The screeners' scores and comments are used to eliminate about 50 percent of all the proposals overall. The remaining applications are divided into groups of approximately 60 and are sent to four panels of five or six distinguished scholars, all of whom read the applications. These panels then convene at ACLS to discuss each application and to select awardees.¹¹

The most important actors in the evaluation process are the program officers, full-time employees of funding agencies who are responsible for running funding competitions. They typically hold a PhD in a discipline covered by the fellowship program. This expertise is necessary if they are to understand the substantive content of the proposals and help orient the deliberations. While some program officers have migrated to funding agencies from academic administration or research (in some cases, after being denied tenure), others are hired by the agency immediately after receiving their PhDs. Program officers' responsibilities include selecting screeners and panelists, communicating with and directing the two groups during the evaluation process, communicating with applicants, and supervis-

ing the organization and distribution of applications. They also preside over panel deliberations, or they appoint a panel chair who takes on this role (in close collaboration with the officer, who even if not officiating, remains present throughout the deliberations). Either way, they play a crucial role in setting the tone of panels. They facilitate interactions, promote collegiality, diffuse tensions (often through humor), ensure efficacy, and engage in “repair work” when customary rules of evaluation are broken.¹² They also help uphold the “sacredness” of the process, that is, the panelists’ belief in the value of peer review (see Chapter 4). Although they instruct panelists about evaluation criteria and program priorities, program officers do not force panelists to respect these guidelines. As we will see, panelists are given full sovereignty over decision making.

Although program officers are not recognized as experts or “peers” (because they are not expert researchers), they have great discretionary powers that affect competition outcomes. First, they define the composition of individual panels, which many people believe is the single most important determinant of which proposals succeed. Program officers can also terminate panelists whose behavior or level of participation is disappointing, and they can promote good screeners to the role of panelists. These responsibilities give them some leverage over those academics who feel overly empowered by their position as judges or very eager to be asked back. For the most part, though, program officers’ power is of the indirect, agenda-setting kind.¹³ This is alluded to by a sociologist who compared his experiences serving on a panel for multiple years. He spoke appreciatively of a previous program officer, who privileged panelists who were “liberal arts people more interested in interdisciplinary work and in new lines of work.” The current incumbent, who is much less to this sociologist’s liking, seems to prefer panelists who are in “second-tier research institutions, who are very solid, reasonably productive, but by and large, precisely the inertial forces that maintain this merry

core, if you will. No one who's about to push the envelope anywhere."

To understand fully the role and influence of program officers, we have to consider the selection of evaluators. Screeners and panelists can be chosen from various pools. Typically, they are academic experts who are very highly regarded in their field. In three of the five programs, they are chosen from among former award recipients; in another, the Society of Fellows, they are chosen from the faculty of a particular university. In the fifth competition, they are chosen among experts in the field.

Panelists are identified by the funding agency—that is, by the program officer—through consultation with other experts in the field. The process is similar across four funding organizations (the Society of Fellows is somewhat different). The description provided in an internal ACLS document is representative:

All screeners and panelists are accomplished tenured faculty or independent scholars of comparable attainment. The ACLS board of directors approves screeners and select panelists. All screeners and panelists are drawn from a database built up through consultation with the Board, Delegates to the Council, Administrative Officers of the Learned Societies, and Learned Societies Presidents.¹⁴

Because there are some differences in the selection of panelists versus screeners, we will consider each separately.

The Selection of Panelists

The selection of high-quality panelists is crucial to the prestige of the fellowship program. As the ACLS's now-deceased president John D'Arms explained:

We try to make sure that our selection panels are composed of distinguished scholars, tough-minded but also broad-minded and prepared to learn from the work of others as well as to judge it. We believe that panelists' careful reading of applications, followed by a full day's discussion of proposals with their colleagues here at ACLS, enlarges panelists' own understanding of the scholarly Humanities, and widens their vision. And we believe that the consensus that panelists reach at the end of their discussion helps to establish national standards of quality. Our aim is to ensure that the ACLS Fellowship is regarded across the country as the result of a process that is at once rigorous, well-informed, venturesome, and fair.¹⁵

This description emphasizes the dispositions of the panelists ("tough-minded but also broad-minded") and the moral quality of the process ("venturesome and fair").¹⁶ It plays up the role of funding panels in setting standards of quality nationwide. In all cases, the status of individuals who serve on panels is presented as an important (if not exclusive) guarantor of the legitimacy of the evaluation. The reputation of the funding organization also contributes to overall legitimacy, as does a tradition of funding significant work. Thus funding organizations often make the names of panelists public when announcing the outcome of a competition. It is the job of program officers to identify evaluators of sufficient caliber and commitment to ensure the ongoing legitimacy of the award programs. At the very least, these evaluators have to believe in the legitimacy of this system. That they have themselves often won fellowships and awards facilitates strong identification with a culture of excellence that is centered on the technology of peer review. After all, their awards are proof that they have submitted themselves repeatedly to this mode of evaluation.

Program officers, who typically cultivate relationships with a wide

array of trusted academics and funding agency insiders, survey this network (sometimes through “gossip”) to identify evaluators who present the desired intellectual and personal dispositions. The degree of autonomy that officers have in this selection process varies across organizations, but it tends to be considerable—at least, this is what program officers state.¹⁷ They may consult with leading experts, panel chairs, members of the board of directors of the funding organization, heads of foundations, and other program officers in order to identify likely panelists. They draw on their networks, but within limits given their need to recruit a wide range of experts.¹⁸ One political scientist highlights the role of networks in describing how her acquaintance with a program officer and a panel chair influenced her own selection as a panelist:

I don't blame [the program officer and panel chair] for choosing people [whom the chair would] know, because [otherwise] you could really get yourself into a real mess. You could have a very inefficient and non-fair committee if you didn't have faith in the judgment of the people that you chose. And that comes from network[ing] . . . And I think I have a reputation for accepting a pretty broad range of work and not having a bias.

In putting together a panel, program officers consider the overall composition of the panel as it pertains to “balance in perspectives,” complementary coverage of wide areas of scholarship and disciplines, and diversity. At a minimum, panels should include some women, individuals teaching in universities outside the Northeast, and individuals who teach in nonelite institutions. Ideally, they should also include some people of color—depending on the size of the panel (in this study, panels ranged from three to sixteen members). This diversity is essential given the character of the American higher education system, where legitimacy is grounded in expertise as well

as in universalism and openness. An alternative model, where panelists are selected from among individuals affiliated with the most elite schools, would be unthinkable; in the American context, democracy, universalism, and rationality all must be present in the decision process.¹⁹

Panelists are expected to form an opinion on proposals covering a variety of topics and representing a range of disciplines. In the course of deliberations, they must be able to judge a large number of proposals while absorbing new information provided by other panelists. They are also expected to know how to offer convincing support for their determinations. These expectations are similar to those they must meet in their daily work lives as producers of research and assessors of evidence.²⁰ Not surprisingly, then, they generally are both more senior and more experienced than screeners. Panelists are also generally more broadly respected and have greater name recognition. Finally, while screeners do not interact with other evaluators, panelists are chosen for their good interpersonal skills, because they are expected to engage in face-to-face negotiation during panel deliberations. Thus beyond the bottom line—that the panelist “not be an asshole”—program officers look for academics who demonstrate such key qualities as “breadth, articulatedness, confidence, and friendliness,” along with flexibility and the ability to work quickly. (Characteristics of a good panelist are explored in greater depth in Chapter 4). Panel members’ ability to help maintain a pleasant tone throughout the deliberation is essential to the group’s success, because it lowers the probability that individuals will dig in their heels and cause conflicts to erupt.

Once program officers have identified panelists who fit the bill, they need to convince them to serve. This can take some persuasion, given that high-level academics are often already shouldering many other professional obligations, and rigorous peer review can be “mentally exhausting,” as a historian of South India puts it. The

attractiveness of the invitation will vary with the potential panelist's career stage, whether she has served on other panels in the distant or recent past, and the level of her commitments in future months. Stated motivations range from a desire to define the agenda, provide a community service, be exposed to new ideas, measure oneself against other high-status experts, and test one's own status and self-concept.

The appeals of prestige and the opportunity to shape competition outcomes and affect the trajectory of other scholars ("power") are often attractive to prospective panelists. The same historian who describes panel deliberations as "exhausting" explains:

[You have] a handful of people who for whatever reason have been chosen to kind of be the arbiters of future directions of doctoral work . . . This is one of the most prestigious scholarships for grad students in the United States. I can't think of any other that actually competes with it. [You're] kind of shaping the direction of the future in various fields by giving a certain message through the funding.

Another panelist, an anthropologist, similarly stresses that

People who serve on important panels certainly are able to shape things, in terms of who gets accolades . . . It's defining who gets defined as excellent, and then gets to get ensconced in positions in universities to train students of the next generation, and on and on and on. Even who gets linked to the funders themselves to think about how they're going to redefine their criteria or reshape their grant giving . . . I'd like to see some really good studies of [these sorts] of political repercussions and dynamics. [They] aren't spoken [of], at least in my world. I mean we all know who the power players are to a certain extent and who's getting invited . . . to be readers for what.

Despite the attraction of the opportunity to exercise influence, many panelists deliberately do not publicize their role, in hopes of avoiding pressure from colleagues or questions about the details of deliberations. They prefer anonymity over awkwardness of this sort.

For some panelists, too, the prime motivation for service is not power but the highly pleasurable opportunity it provides for learning what is going on in a variety of fields. In the words of an African-American historian, “It’s good to get just a sense of what’s happening in the field and find out what is piquing the interests of the scholars writing their dissertations. When we come together as a group, it’s fun to see what the other people are thinking about, what they find interesting and how our ideas kind of meld or don’t meld together . . . I feel like I learn things, things that I didn’t know, or get a better understanding.” New information can of course influence the research agenda of panelists and improve their own grant proposals.

Others explain their willingness to serve in rather disinterested terms. One refers to a sense of “noblesse oblige. [This funding agency] had given me fellowships on two previous occasions and I felt a sense of obligation.” A literary scholar says he agreed to serve because he “just took it as one of those burdens that I would one time or another have to bear. [Once] I was approached more than four times and I just saw it as, ‘I can’t escape it.’ . . . I don’t go out looking for extra work for myself. Plus, I don’t know what is ultimately a gain for me.” A third panelist, by contrast, cheerfully admits being lured by the combination of an honorarium (rarely offered) and the opportunity to travel to the attractive city where the deliberations were held.

Still others value the opportunity to interact with “other really smart people” and the associated pleasure that kind of interaction so often brings to academics. An English professor recounts:

I was very happy to find that I agreed with [a female panelist] on many evaluations where the two of us were different from the other panelists. I was very pleased by that because I admire her

because of her field. What she does is maybe more akin to what I do, because some of her work is very strongly inflected with feminist influence . . . I remember enjoying her book immensely . . . We are interested in [similar topics], which created similarities in our evaluations.

Another panelist says, “I remember having a couple of moments of very pleasurable agreement with the medievalist. It had to do with reading major classics against the grain . . . There again, it just seemed a moment of connecting, but I couldn’t really describe it in abstract term[s].” Such moments of connection are particularly important given the rather isolated character of academic work. They are also valued because relatively few people share the knowledge needed to appreciate scholarship in an informed fashion. A number of interviewees describe experiencing moments of individual or collective effervescence during deliberations. These feelings are prompted by a variety of factors, but some respondents note as especially powerful moments those times they felt they were in deep agreement with others on what defines good work, or times when they felt the group as a whole had forged a connection around specific research projects.²¹

If these academics have a personal interest in serving on panels, it appears to be as much about finding intrinsic rewards—the pleasure of reading good proposals—and in building relationships they find rewarding as it is about maximizing their position within intellectual fields. These elements of pleasure, which many respondents noted, are utterly absent from Bourdieu’s description of the academic field.²² For his part, Collins associates the effervescence of intellectuals with the emotional energy that comes from being at the center of attention.²³ But emotional energy can come from sharing important experiences. Considering the plurality of self-concepts among academics enriches our understanding of their motivations.²⁴

In interviews, many evaluators expressed concern for their performance on the panel. Serving gave them an occasion to assess whether they measured up to the role they were asked to fill; they wanted to meet or exceed expectations. At a minimum, one must convince colleagues of the value of some of one's favorite proposals in order to come away from the deliberations with an intact sense of dignity. Thus deliberations are a context for presenting an ideal self or a perceived expected self, and perhaps even for measuring oneself against others. They are also a context where each panelist affirms the identity of others as valued experts. Although this aspect of peer review has not been discussed in standard accounts, it may be particularly valued because members of this group experience quite a bit of ambiguity about their relative status and worth, even as they spend much of their time judging the performance of others and are supposed to be strongly committed to quality.

Serving on panels also has the performative effect of sustaining faith in how the academic community identifies and produces quality. Service reasserts commitment to the process while also giving panelists a chance to improve it. This affirmation contributes to the feeling of effervescence, which can also result from the experience of distributing money to facilitate good work, from taking pride in participating in a process that is perceived as fair, or perhaps even from the collective exercise of "opportunity hoarding."²⁵

The Role of Screeners

Screeners are generally highly regarded associate or (in a few cases) assistant professors whose mentors have recommended them to program officers. They are invited to serve because they are recognized as having high standards and good judgment, although, again, they are not expected to have the intellectual breadth and experience of panelists. Neither do they need the same interpersonal skills because

they are not involved in face-to-face deliberations. As the description of the ACLS process presented earlier suggests, the screeners' job is to weed out unpromising proposals submitted by applicants working within the screeners' area of expertise. To borrow from Mitchell Stevens in his study of the admission process at an elite college, their task is that of coarse sorting, as opposed to making fine distinctions.²⁶ The rankings that screeners assign shape the list of proposals the panelists will evaluate and discuss.

In many ways, the role of screener has little to recommend it. These evaluators are not remunerated for what is often a very time-consuming task, their identity is often kept confidential, and they do not have the final say in which research receives support. But because being asked to serve is a badge of honor—a sure sign of the value that the academic community attaches to the individual's opinion—more junior and mid-career academics often are happy to serve in this capacity. Acting as a screener may add status and stability to their identity at what often is an unstable stage in their professional trajectory.

Screeners generally serve for one year and are invited to serve again if the program officer is satisfied with their work; they are rarely asked to serve for more than a few years, however. They are usually given several weeks to read and rate the proposals, but typically they receive very little guidance concerning what is expected of them. There is considerable variation in the care that screeners put into their tasks. For instance, some provide panelists with information regarding the proposals—they jot a few words or a few lines on each application—others provide nothing more than their ranking for each. Program officers exercise quality control. Their decision to “re-invite” screeners to serve is influenced by the care the screeners take in doing their tasks. For their part, panelists usually have the option of “checking” the work of screeners, but they rarely do so. In one of the competitions I studied, however, panelists became convinced,

given the screener's written comments, that a particular type of project had been judged excessively harshly. Consequently, the panel elected to revisit all the eliminated proposals. Attributing such problems to a lack of experience among screeners, a historian explains:

There were questions of both style and standard. Some people just are reluctant to give out high [ranks], and in a competition where a median figure might be enough to eliminate you, that could be a deadly . . . Others seem to have standards that we didn't agree with, where they reacted very strongly to a particular proposal. We looked at it and said, "Wait a minute. That's not a reason to eliminate this proposal." And one of those standards seemed . . . fairly arbitrary, [a] decision about the lack of a specific time schedule for the research. [This should not be] an absolute standard for making or breaking a proposal.

The Work of Panelists

Panelists are responsible for evaluating the applications of those in the pool of finalists. Typically, they assign a ranking to each, based on a scale of one to five (or A to E); build cases in favor of or against candidates; discuss these evaluations with other members of the panel; and make final recommendations concerning recipients. As suggested earlier, this job requires multiple types of expertise, the foremost of which are familiarity with several literatures and the ability to compare and assess a wide range of materials (the panelists I interviewed each had been asked to evaluate and rank anywhere from eighteen to eighty proposals). They usually have a month or so to study the applications and accompanying material and come up with rankings. In most cases, this reading and evaluating is "squeezed" into a schedule already overpacked with teaching; communicating formally and informally with colleagues; meeting

with and advising graduate students; serving on departmental, university-wide, and professional committees; doing research; and writing books and papers.²⁷ Many panelists say they use time usually spent with their families to evaluate proposals, which often consumes weekends. For instance, a sociologist explains that he spent a whole weekend reading his eighteen proposals, allotting forty minutes to each.

Panel members recognize that they all do not put the same amount of time and care into their evaluations. A political scientist describes herself as much more careful than her fellow panelists: “I remembered the proposals [during deliberations]. I had much more detail about the proposals than some of the people. Some of them had read them a long time before the conference.” An art historian, a first-time panelist, was frustrated and embarrassed to discover—during deliberations—that she had not put in as much time as others: “It comes at the worst time in the academic year. I had just gotten two piles of papers for grading for both classes at the time that these [proposals] arrived. And I did read them, but I obviously didn’t read them the same way that [other panelists] did.” Degree of preparedness affects how convincing panelists are to their peers.

In addition to relying on the rankings and comments provided by screeners, panelists normally base the judgments they make before their panel convenes on some or all of the following evidence: the applicant’s biographical sketch, personal statement, curriculum vitae (specifically, past honors and awards, institutions attended, courses taken, employment, travel, and language competency), research project description, bibliography, project timetable, examples of past work, grade transcript, letters of recommendation, teaching experience and interests, statement of commitment to the goal of the funding program, and availability of other sources of funding. In one case—the Society of Fellows—the panel also conducts in-person interviews with finalists. As we will see in Chapter 5, panelists assign

different weights to these pieces of evidence—particularly to the proposal, the project, and the applicant (including the letters describing her and her work). They may also mobilize additional resources. An American historian, for instance, describes going to his own bookshelf to consult a standard book on Middle Eastern history in order to better assess the claims of originality made by a particular proposal.²⁸

Panelists typically serve for two or three years. A rotation system ensures continuity and helps new panel members learn the customary rules of deliberation. The benefit of this system is clear in the comments that panelists made contrasting their experiences from year to year (since they serve on panels for at least two years, seventeen of the panelists who participated in the study were interviewed twice). The art historian quoted earlier explains that the first year she served, she graded too liberally because she had “misunderstood” what was expected. “I suppose in many cases, my ones could have been two’s and three’s, and certainly my two’s were three’s and four’s . . . That was very disconcerting because I did not come prepared to cite [from the proposals].” As a result, other panelists came to see her as having “low standards,” which she found very upsetting. Another panelist explains that he learned from his experience the first year, when he had graded “easy,”

a better sense of where to throw my ones and where to throw my lower scores, and when not to try and push it. Last year, for example, I gave a one to a proposal that was one-hundred-eighty degrees different than anything I think I myself would ever do . . . But it was so ambitious, and in a way so crazy, that I kind of liked it. Well, that was one of those discussions where essentially I made my case [and people] just looked at me and said, “That sounds more like you’re arguing against this guy.” . . . Everybody does a certain amount of role playing in these kinds of things.

Panelists note that the evaluation process is not straightforward because criteria change as one reads through the stack of applications. Most panelists take notes on each of the proposals and candidates while reading and then periodically revisit their rankings in an iterative process, with the result that, according to a political scientist, “One really does come to the session with a fairly clear recall of most of the applications.” As they discover what the pool of applicants looks like, panelists often come to see that proposals shine under very different lights, that different standards apply to different proposals, and that proposals do not all win or lose for the same reason. As one panelist puts it:

[One proposal] was very strong on originality, kind of ambitious, and weak on the actual presentation. It was overwritten. And the other proposal was actually uninteresting, but well presented. They had opposite pluses and minuses, so the argument was why should we fund this one and not do a similar kind of calculation for the other one, but in the opposite way.

Experience allows one to put incommensurable proposals like these on the same matrix and draw conclusions (more on this in Chapter 4).²⁹ Different characteristics—for instance, originality or significance—can push a proposal above the proverbial line. The evaluation process is not consistent or linear. As a historian says:

If we could get fifty good, empirically grounded, significant proposals that had a reasonable comparative dimension to them, I would certainly go for those . . . [in practice] it’s a matter of picking among twenty flawed proposals. [A proposal] that’s sort of internally sophisticated and empirically important, but lacks that comparative or fashionable focus, is something that I would prob-

ably go for over something I thought was sloppy even if it was full of ideas.

Panelists perform much of their work in isolation and develop their own method of evaluation. One panelist, for example, first reads all the proposals in alphabetical order, and then by field, before giving any grade. Another describes her evaluation process thus:

[The applications] are read about three times by the time I turn in my final grade, and some of them are read more than that. I read them once without grading them, then I go back and I grade them. Then I let them sit for a few days, then I go back and do the final grades. And in some instances, I might have read something several times . . . I knocked some scores up because I knew that they would get discussed if I gave them any kind of A, and I needed them discussed. Even though I do interdisciplinary work, I don't know everything coming out in history, and I needed help evaluating those.

This individualized approach is not surprising given that much like screeners, panelists do not receive formal training in the evaluation of proposals. Generally, the guidance provided by program officers to panelists is limited to information concerning the goals of the competition, the criteria to be considered, and perhaps a list of past awardees. Evaluators are not furnished with guidelines that dwell on what is being evaluated (the individual or the project), the specific meaning of the selection criteria to be used (for example, how to recognize originality and significance), or the weight to be given to each criterion (such as standards of excellence versus geographic distribution of awardees). Decisions in such areas are left to the discretion of the evaluators, who are expected to have learned

how to conduct valid assessments over the course of their careers. And so most have—acquiring this skill in much the same way as they have learned many other tasks, that is, by themselves and by observing their more experienced colleagues and mentors.³⁰ An anthropologist explains how in the absence of “training,” panelists nevertheless learn what is expected of them:

I have been in a lot of grant review committees and I can't recall ever really [having] any training . . . It is a little bit difficult to think of training senior scholars. There are a lot of shared norms I think in academia, American academia, at least in research universities, from which most of these people are drawn . . . I think we, first of all, tend to judge people pretty heavily on their ability to contribute to major journals in the field . . . And we are impressed by people who are well-published, in that sense [of] publishing in major university presses and so on . . . The first time I was on a panel, I was probably thirty years old or something, I [wondered how we could do] it . . . Having now been on so many different kinds of panels, I would say I was curious to see whether there would be disagreement [among the experts] and so forth, but I [was not] struck by the difficulty of making evaluations. [It has become] natural.

Similarly, a political scientist believes that panelists do not need formal training in evaluation because

It's the kind of stuff we do all our lives . . . Teaching, criticizing other people's work, reading articles for courses that you're going to teach. I mean, all we do is criticize and pick apart people's arguments, think about their variables, think about all the things that I talked about. No, I don't think we need any special training at all.

After a panel has completed its deliberations, the program officer often assesses the session and decides whether to ask the panel members to serve again. Among the panels I studied, there were a very few cases where an individual was not reinvited, either because he or she did not demonstrate the expected level of expertise (as evidenced by seeming wishy-washy or hesitant to express an opinion), or because of an apparent lack of essential interpersonal skills. Despite routinely making these “private assessments,” program officers rarely provide panelists with information that would assist them in improving their own performance as judges—doing so could be awkward given the scholarly authority of the panelists. Nor do program officers provide information on the performance of past awardees, which could be useful for improving the selection process. When a formal evaluation of the panel is conducted—for instance, when a program is reviewed by an external committee—reports tend to remain in the hands of funding program personnel. Panelists are never confronted with the consequences of their deliberative choices, as they are when they select their future graduate students or when they approve tenure for colleagues. They are presumed to be responsible professionals who set high standards for themselves, and they are accorded full or nearly full sovereignty over the decision-making process. This autonomy adds weight to the selection process, and to the role that program officers play in it.

The Mechanics of Panel Deliberation

Panelists typically meet for a day or two, usually in the office of the funding agency, to discuss proposals. While some panels make funding decisions, others make funding recommendations, which are followed almost without exception. Commonly, once panel members have assembled, they are given a list of the proposals under consideration as well as the cumulative rating each has received from all the

panelists.³¹ The meeting generally begins with an explanation of the rules of deliberation, articulated by the panel chair and/or the program officer. These rules may specify, for instance, whether the panel operates by consensus or voting and whether all proposals (that is, even those with low ratings) will be discussed.

The panel chair and/or the program officer are responsible for orchestrating the deliberation, keeping the discussion moving, ensuring that all panelists have a chance to express an opinion on each proposal (if they wish), and seeing to it that applicants receive a fair hearing. They also in principle oversee the quality of the deliberation—by making sure that substantive arguments, rather than pure cost-benefit analyses, are made.

The chair and program officer must manage overbearing personalities (a sure sign of a poor panelist), prevent the formation of excessive alliances and allegiances, and forestall strong, potentially acrimonious disagreements. As we will see in Chapter 4, they also have to undertake emotional repair work when a panelist feels slighted (which may happen if his expertise is not given proper recognition, or if he believes that another panelist is not showing proper respect for a field or a topic).³² Success in these endeavors requires that panelists respect both the chair and the program officer. Respect may be granted because of their skills and experience at running panels. Age, gender, race, known professional trajectory, and institutional affiliation (in the case of panel chairs) also have an effect.³³ One panelist explicitly attributed the success of her panel to the program officer: “I was amazed with how willing the panelists were and how accepting . . . It may have been because of the context, of the program officer . . . I don’t know if it’s the way she chose, I’m not even sure if she’s the chooser, but the way she created the ethos was really exceptional [in setting the tone] and also moving us along, because we had a huge amount of work.” A panel chair, by contrast, forfeited the respect of some members of his panel by alternating between the

roles of an evaluator and a chair. This switching made it impossible for him to seem neutral when coordinating the deliberations; consequently, his credibility in both capacities was undermined. Another chair was strongly criticized for his patronizing and time-wasting managerial style. A panelist describes him as repeatedly saying, “This is what we’re doing,’ when everyone knew what we were doing. It was time to move on. So there was a language that was employed that was exhausting and repetitious and maybe unnecessary. And I think it probably could have been cut off.”

During deliberations, a panel typically works its way from the top of the list of applicants (those receiving the largest number of high marks) to the bottom. It is generally understood that applicants who received the highest total rating prior to the meeting will receive funding, so those cases may be noted at the start of deliberations, but they are not usually discussed. Likewise, applications that received low ratings often are not discussed. The bulk of the deliberations concern the applicants whose proposals have received mixed ratings, a group whose size depends on what proportion of the proposals will be funded. As an economist explained:

The applications that were ranked six hundred and seven hundred, you could tell in ten seconds [that they were no good]. It just gets harder the closer you get to the cutoff and that’s where we spent more time. So I think there’s a time constraint in all our lives and we have to focus attention on some things. I don’t think people got short shrift in terms of the amount of time. I think it was reasonable. You’re not going to do any better than this.

The “middle of the pack” proposals, those that receive mixed ratings, are flawed, but their faults differ. The greatest challenge for panelists is often the comparison of incommensurate flaws. These middle-rank proposals consume the most time because individual

panelists tend to weight differently the proposals' relative strengths and weaknesses. Hence debate about the relative importance of criteria and the meaning of specific criteria is a defining aspect of a panel's effort to constitute the "second half" of the list. When comparing proposals in this category, panel members also bring considerations of interdisciplinarity and diversity into the picture.

While on some panels someone is appointed to present each proposal, this was not the case in the panels I studied. The deliberations proceed at a fairly fast pace, with each panelist in turn being asked to provide an opinion. In order to refresh their memories, panelists often refer to notes they took when initially evaluating the applications and then offer arguments in favor or against proposals. Many have rehearsed arguments in advance, mentally comparing proposals as part of their effort to produce their own rankings in preparation for the meeting. After either only a few exchanges or more lengthy discussions, the program officer or chair gives his or her reading of the emerging consensus, and concludes with a recommendation. If there is no consensus, the proposal is generally set aside to be revisited later. A panelist describes the merits of this approach:

Instead of anyone digging in their heels and saying, "If you don't fund this I'm going to . . ." which I have seen people do, we said, "Let's hold this and come back to it." Then by the time we've gone through the whole cycle of applications, things were clearer. I thought at the very end, where we were deciding for five [spots] among thirteen [applications], I thought that worked much more quickly than it might have . . . So I found it very congenial.

The discussion of the first proposals under consideration is lengthier than discussions held later because at the start of deliberation, panelists are also presenting their own expertise and back-

ground, defining their identity in relation to that of other panelists. As an economist puts it: “I suppose that’s sort of what you learn during the first few hours of debate at one of these panels . . . you get a sense of each person, of well, they care about this, they don’t care about that, maybe they’re the only representative of this field here, but they come as the ambassador for that field.” They also mark their territory, indicating the areas in which they believe they should be recognized as having greater authority.³⁴

A political scientist points out that the first rounds of deliberation are also an occasion for individuals to “show off how smart [they] are”; that is, this is when panelists typically signal their particular fields and topic of expertise. As such, panel deliberations are also the occasion for “performing the self”—displaying one’s verbal virtuosity and cultural capital among other academics.³⁵ As we will see in Chapter 4, such displays have a crucial effect on the interpersonal dynamics of the group.

As panelists get to know one another, and move from the “easiest” to the less consensual proposals, they develop a “group style.”³⁶ Indeed, a historian explains, “When you sit on these committees, particularly from year to year, you increasingly get a sense of how other people see things, you can kind of predict [their arguments].” Many panelists also use the context of the panel to clarify their opinion about specific proposals and to gather additional information regarding currently available work on the topic. This aspect of deliberations is noted by a historian who, when asked if he was disappointed that some of the proposals were not funded, says:

There were several cases in which I literally had question marks and I thought it looked like excellent and promising work, but I didn’t think I understood it well enough. So I found myself asking questions more than making a case when I intervened in the dis-

cussion, and then was convinced that perhaps it was not my failure to understand something, but rather that the project wasn't completely thought through.

Conversely, this same historian explains that other panelists turned to him for his historical expertise:

I knew that my colleagues would occasionally look to me to explain the situation [of the proposal] within the discipline—is this where the work is going, is this a valuable set of sources, what is this proposal missing, all sorts of things. So I tended to really focus a good deal on those, simply because I accepted it as my responsibility to be able to answer questions that others might have.

Undoubtedly, the multidisciplinary character of the panels I studied reinforces the interdependence of panelists when it comes to obtaining the knowledge needed to assess proposals. But across all types of panels, the evaluators also depend on one another for subtle nonverbal signals concerning the value of proposals (eye rolling, shoulder shrugging, nodding, smiling admiringly, and so on)—signals that help them “satisfice” or make the best choices possible given the limitations of their own knowledge and their current context.³⁷

As suggested in Chapter 1, face-to-face conversations are seen as leading to better decisions. John Dewey, for one, believed that debating is important for the emergence of shared standards about fairness and for developing trust.³⁸ Accordingly, deliberating forces panelists to articulate their argument in the context of a dialogue—a process that may produce more transparent, less controllable decisions, and decisions that take into consideration contextual information. As a technology for decision making, deliberation helps neutralize conflicts and encourages interdisciplinary conversations,

despite perceived inequalities of prestige and influence across disciplines.³⁹ It also makes room for improvisation and hunches, as panelists elaborate on their arguments in the heat of the moment.⁴⁰ This system is to be contrasted with mechanized forms of evaluation that attempt to remove all traces of the personal, the idiosyncratic, and the inconsistent.⁴¹ Funding agencies use peer review because they can mobilize acknowledged experts, that is, an evaluative technology that puts connoisseurship and judgments at the center of the evaluation process.

Conclusion

As we will see, many applicants and panelists strongly support grant peer review because it is perceived as guaranteeing a relatively clean evaluation process. As such, it legitimizes the system of distribution of resources for evaluators and applicants, and beyond that, affirms the broader system of academic evaluation and promotion, including tenure. To some extent peer review is where agreement on quality is accomplished and where the principle of meritocracy is unquestioned. In contrast, to take only one example, in the French workplace studied by sociologist François Dubet, several forces are opposed to the meritocratic distribution of resources because it privileges the dominant and penalizes the subordinate groups.⁴²

As a technology producing relative “cleanliness,” peer review plays an especially crucial role in the American context, at least as compared to its role in “smaller” systems like those of Hungary, Finland, or Portugal. The sheer demographic size of American higher education, as well as the impersonal nature and level of social and geographic mobility that characterize it, generate uncertainty concerning shared norms and rules of behavior, and threaten to undermine organizational control.⁴³ Under these conditions, it is particularly important that individuals who have never met know immedi-

ately what is expected of them when they find themselves in the same room, and so they do, thanks to widely shared institutionalized norms that regulate the system of national competition.⁴⁴ Trust in the peer review system is crucial because, by definition, it rejects the vast majority of applicants, who could easily lose faith. Thus this system maintains representations of itself as open and driven by meritocracy, in strong contrast with a not-too-distant past when academia conspicuously favored more culturally homogeneous religious, ethnic, and class elites.⁴⁵

As the next chapter will make clear, in the context of this clearly defined technology of peer review and the relative consensus that surrounds it, the evaluative cultures of academic disciplines vary greatly—so much so that it can seem like a minor miracle that consensus emerges from this sea of differences, and that the black box can actually produce awards.